

Calculated or Sacred? AI Horoscope Applications and What Vietnamese Fortune Telling Is Actually For

Background Information

Tử Vi and the Role of the Practitioner

In Vietnamese culture, when a person is deciding on a marriage date or a business location, it is extremely common for them to look at what is known as "Tử Vi", which is the traditional system of astrological fortune telling and is determined by the person's birth date and lunar calendar alignments. Because of its popularity, when planning for major events, many families seek help from a local practitioner known as a "thầy tử vi", in which the advisor would offer personal advice and help a person make sense of their future luck.

AI Enters the Practice

However, in today's world, the rapid growth of technology is changing the way we are looking for Tử Vi guidance. For instance, Vietnam's national AI adoption rate climbed to 26.5 percent in early 2026 (Thanh Van). This reveals the massive implementation of AI on a daily basis in Vietnam. As a result, software developers are building AI-powered fortune telling platforms that generate personalized horoscopes without having to visit a traditional advisor (thầy tử vi). Real AI tools are already being implemented in the Vietnamese marketplace, such as AIuvi and Thái Âm, which are AI applications that function by having an individual enter their birth date and exact hour into the application. Afterwards, the AI will generate charts revealing a person's daily financial luck score. Additionally, for mobile applications, an application called "AI Tử Vi - Vận Hạn 2026" offers a built-in AI chatbot that acts as an automated fortune advisor. When using the mobile application, a person can type in a question and the chatbot will analyze his or her planetary stars to give them specific suggestions.

The Philosophical Question

Though the concept only took off in 2023, AI horoscope applications have spread quickly among young Vietnamese people, who can now get a tử vi reading in seconds for free ("When Gen Z Becomes Superstitious"). That convenience raises a philosophical question: when an AI app predicts a person's fortune, is that person getting real spiritual guidance or just computer data?

Hubert Dreyfus and the Limits of Machine Intuition

Expertise as Embodied Experience

One compelling point of view comes from Hubert Dreyfus, who argued that human expertise cannot be replaced by computer codes or scripts (Dreyfus). To be more specific, Dreyfus pointed out that human wisdom comes from embodied experience, meaning that human experts rely on personal feelings and deep social intuition in order to give advice or make a prediction. Conversely, an AI application does not have the ability to evaluate external factors but rather is dependent on data to make a suggestion.

Consequently, when applying this idea to the concept of Tử Vi AI applications, it is clear that these AI applications are altering traditional fortune telling. To be precise, in Vietnamese culture, financial luck connects to a person's character, so a fortune telling practitioner reads a person's chart while discussing their morals simultaneously. For example, even if a person's stars show wealth, an experienced practitioner warns him or her against unethical shortcuts. Moreover, fortune tellers usually ask direct questions about an individual's family and debts to give advice that actually fits his or her life. On the other hand, AI applications, though fast, are often not as thoughtful; the system simply uses a person's data to calculate a financial luck score while ignoring a person's moral character or real-life risks. For instance, if a person plans to open a new business, an AI app might see a lucky star in that person's chart and tell him or her to expand immediately. A physical thầy tử vi, however, will ask if the client is carrying heavy bank loans or supporting aging parents. If the family cannot handle a financial risk, the seer will advise delaying the expansion.

This shows why relying on AI applications for advice might not be entirely beneficial. The reason for this is that when using AI, the system is not taking into account external factors, but rather deciding a person's fortune through data lines such as birth dates or the lunar calendar. Overall, Dreyfus warns us that the usage of AI in order to give advice might cause inaccurate and meaningless predictions (Dreyfus).

Max Weber and the Disenchantment of Fate

Technology and the Loss of Mystery

Another important perspective comes from the philosophy of Max Weber, a sociologist and philosopher who studied how modern technology changes human society. In his lecture titled Science as a Vocation, published in 1919, Weber argued that as society relies more on technology, it would eliminate the mysterious and sacred aspects of our society (Weber). More specifically, technology coerces a person to view everything as something that can be calculated with numbers.

The Birth Chart as Probability

Consequently, when applying Weber's philosophy to the context of AI Tử Vi applications, it is clear that this software is altering the traditional nature of fortune telling. Traditional Tử Vi views a person's birth chart as a sacred map that connects a person's life to spiritual harmony. However, AI changes the birth chart of a person

into probability numbers that can be calculated with an algorithm, which removes the spiritual factors within Tử Vi.

All in all, Weber directly points out that an AI app is not capable of giving us spiritual directions because it disenchants the practice (Weber). To be more precise, when computer algorithms change a tradition that is meant to be spiritual into a series of probability and numbers, it ruins the mystery aspects that make the guidance from practitioners valuable in the first place.

Counterpoint: Spinoza and the Case for Objectivity

A Universe of Mathematical Law

Although there are disadvantages when implementing AI into the field of Tử Vi, a strong opposing argument comes from the perspective of Baruch Spinoza. Applied to this debate, Spinoza's framework suggests that AI actually purifies fortune telling by removing human flaws and personal bias. To be more specific, Spinoza argued that the universe exists through mathematical laws rather than human emotions (Spinoza). Spinoza suggests that moods and personal desires usually distort the truth.

Removing the Human Incentive to Deceive

When this idea is applied to AI fortune telling applications, they provide the user with more objective guidance. This is because under the ideas of Spinoza, traditional fortune telling was never meant to be based on personal thinking but on a mathematical system that is based on planetary position and the lunar calendar cycles. Consequently, although human seers have significantly more experience, they are more subject to greed or bad moods. For instance, a physical thầy tử vi might manipulate a client to charge higher fees and sell unnecessary rituals.

Overall, Spinoza's framework suggests that artificial intelligence can potentially be more beneficial compared to traditional fortune tellers due to the fact that AI applications do not have a reason to give false advice or to manipulate a customer.

Holding the Views Together

Two Standards for Judging the App

When observing this topic from a wider scope, it is clear that there is a dilemma between trusting human wisdom and utilizing technological advantages. According to Hubert Dreyfus and Max Weber, outsourcing fortune telling to an algorithm strips away human empathy and the mystery of the tradition (Dreyfus; Weber). These philosophers warn us that AI can only produce calculated predictions. On the other hand, Baruch Spinoza contends that technology can protect users from human bias and emotional greed by providing objective calculations rather than relying on personal thoughts (Spinoza).

Ultimately, whether an AI fortune telling application is reliable depends on how a person defines the boundaries of true spiritual values within the art of fortune telling. More specifically, if an individual believes true spirituality comes from the judgement and experience of a traditional human practitioner, then advice from an AI model would be meaningless. On the other hand, if a person defines spiritual values as objective advice that is not influenced by other factors, then an AI fortune telling application can still be beneficial.

Works Cited

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